fortepianissimo

A card game of swapping, bluffing and betting on the best or worst hand. Loosely based on Blitz (31).

2+ players · **50** cards · **4** lives each

I What's in the game

50 cards, valued 1 to 10 in five suits:

 **Treble**  **Bass** **Sharp** **Flat**  **Eighth**

Each player has **4 lives** and two tokens: *M* **Major** ("I have the best hand") and *m* **Minor** ("I have the worst hand").

II Setup

1. Shuffle and deal **4 cards** to each player.
2. Deal **4 cards face up** in the center. This is the pool.
3. Turn one more card face up beside the pool. This is the **bests** card, and its suit is bests for the round. It stays out of play.

III Your turn

Play goes left of the dealer. On your turn, do one of these:

- **Swap.** Trade one card from your hand for one card in the pool.
- **Pass.** Keep your hand as it is.
- **Call *"Forte!"*** Only once every player has had at least one turn. Instead of swapping, place one of your tokens face down. Your hand is now locked.

IV After the call

Every other player takes **one last turn** (swap or pass), then places one token face down.

V The reveal

- Everyone shows their hand and flips their token.
- *M* Major is correct if your hand is the **best** at the table.
- *m* Minor is correct if your hand is the **worst** at the table.
- Wrong claim: **lose a life**. A tie that bests can't break counts as correct for everyone in it.

VI Winning

- At 0 lives you're out. The deal passes left each round.
- The **last player standing wins**.
- If everyone still in goes out on the same reveal, the game is a **draw**.

QUICK TURN

Swap one card with the pool, pass, or (after everyone's had a turn) call ***"Forte!"*** and place a token. Then everyone else takes one more turn and places a token. Reveal.

VII Hands, best to worst

Your four cards make a poker hand. A 1 is always low, and straights don't wrap (no 9-10-1-2). Hands are ranked by how rare they are in this deck.

	HAND	EXAMPLE	WAYS
1	**Straight flush** Four in a row, one suit	7♭ 8♭ 9♭ 10♭	35
2	**Four of a kind** Four of one value	6𝄞 6𝄢 6♯ 6♪	50
3	**Flush** Four of one suit	2♯ 5♯ 8♯ 10♯	1,015
4	**Straight** Four in a row	3♯ 4♭ 5𝄞 6♪	4,340
5	**Three of a kind** Three of one value	9𝄞 9𝄢 9♭ 2♪	4,500
6	**Two pair** Two pairs	8𝄢 8♯ 3𝄞 3♪	4,500
7	**Pair** Two of one value	5♭ 5♪ 10𝄞 2𝄢	90,000
8	**High card** None of the above	10𝄢 7𝄞 4♪ 1♭	125,860

"Ways" counts the hands, out of 230,300 possible, that make each rank. With five suits a straight is rarer than three of a kind, so it ranks higher than in regular poker.

SAME KIND OF HAND? BESTS BEFORE VALUES

1. **Bests first.** The hand holding the **highest bests card** wins. How many bests cards you hold doesn't matter.
2. **Then values.** If neither hand holds a bests card, higher values win. A straight goes by its top card; otherwise compare the biggest group first, then the other cards from high to low.
3. **Bests never beats a better kind of hand.** Any two pair beats any pair, bests or not.
4. **Still tied?** No bests cards and the same values. Every tied claim counts as correct.

A bests card lifts your hand above others of its kind, so it helps a Major claim and hurts a Minor claim. With Sharp as bests:

Ana

5𝄞 5♯ 1𝄢 2♭

Pair of 5s with the 5 of Sharps: **wins**

Ben

8𝄞 8𝄢 1♪ 2𝄞

Pair of 8s, no Sharps: loses